Chapter Three

The Keeper's Ledger

The ledger lived on a shelf above the stove, where the damp could not reach it. Every evening Ana took it down, wiped her hands on her apron, and wrote the day in the same square letters her father had taught her: the wind, the sea, the ships that passed, and anything that broke.

Most days there was little to write. A trawler going out before dawn, the same trawler coming back with the gulls behind it, a wind that backed to the west by noon. She liked those days best. The pages filled slowly and evenly, like a tide coming in over flat sand.

It was on one of those quiet evenings that she noticed the gap. Three days in the spring of the year before were missing, not torn out but simply never written, and the next entry began in a hand she did not know. Someone else had kept the light while her father was away, and nobody had ever told her who.

She sat with the ledger open on her knees until the lamp needed trimming. Then she climbed the stairs, saw to the light, and came down again to read the strange entries one more time, slowly, as if the handwriting itself might give up a name.

The stranger wrote small and leaned hard on the pen. Where her father noted a ship by its name and nothing more, this keeper had added the colour of its

hull, the number of men on deck, and once, in the margin, a single line about a woman waving from the stern of a ferry. Ana read that line four times before she closed the book and put it back on the shelf above the stove.